

in 2004, showcased again in 2006, and later at the New York Fashion Week (2006). Anamika Khanna, who recently made her London Fashion Week debut with her brand AK|OK Anamika Khanna on September 22, was India's first female designer at Paris Fashion Week (2007). Almost a decade later, Rahul Mishra won the International Woolmark Prize, which recognises outstanding fashion talents from around the globe, in 2014, and has since been a global force—his was the first Indian brand to be part of the Paris Haute Couture Week (2020).

The couturier recalls the lull prior to his win: “When Divya [Bhatt Mishra, co-founder and Rahul's wife] and I were competing at the Woolmark Prize, the global press hardly noticed us. But once the jury declared me the winner, everything changed—the spotlight was suddenly on India. Once seen as a service provider for luxury embroidery, India is now writing its own story on the global stage.” With a flagship in Mumbai, Rahul will announce a Parisian address next year, one that Divya says will carry the brand's DNA but speak to an international clientele.

In the luxury fashion race, you cannot miss names like Sabyasachi, Gaurav Gupta, Vaishali Shadangule, Manish Malhotra. Often compared to Ralph Lauren on home soil, Sabyasachi's 25-year-old eponymous brand aims to become a \$2 billion enterprise by 2030. Fine credentials back up his India-to-the-world story—a store in New York that opened in 2022; collaborations with Christian Louboutin, Morgenthal Fredericks, and H&M; high jewellery lines exclusive to Bergdorf Goodman, Neiman Marcus San Francisco, and Harrods; a lipstick collection with Estée Lauder; a soon-to-launch fragrance line. Sabyasachi ticks every box for front row representation in global fashion.

Another regular at Paris Haute Couture Week is Gupta, whose “brand has existed in a global dialogue from Couture Week to Met Gala”. While a physical presence in Europe or North America would feel like the next chapter in their story, Gupta wants the expansion “to feel organic”. The challenge, Gupta shares, is creating a space that retains India's spirit yet feels completely at home on



▲ LUXE PARADE

1. **Couturier Gaurav Gupta**
2. **Mohanjeet Grewal, a pioneer of the Indian fashion industry, who set up shop in Paris in the 1960s**
3. **Sabyasachi Mukherjee**

Madison Avenue in New York or Avenue Montaigne in Paris. “For me, the store must educate, engage an audience who may not have grown up with Indian craft, but are excited to experience it.”

With stores in both Mumbai and Paris, Shadangule (the first Indian female designer to showcase at Paris Haute Couture Week in 2021) says, “Niche Indian luxury brands are new and our brand was lucky to start selling from the first month after the Paris Couture show.” However, there are challenges aplenty, as people want to know the brand and see consistency in quality. “Paris has a small diaspora share, so our store is mostly suited for Middle Eastern and American clients, both receptive towards Indian workmanship,” she adds.

Though the West may have been late in giving Indian labels their due, that's not been the case with other regions like the Middle East. It is closer to home and one where Indian sensibilities find common

